The court clerics would not take such a challenge lying down, of course. Makhdum-ul-Mulk persuaded Salim Shah to banish Shaikh Ala'i.

Soon, however, the shah reversed his decision and recalled the shaikh, asking him only to whisper that he had recanted his Mahdawi beliefs. The shaikh refused and Salim Shah had no choice but to order him to be whipped. The punishment was not intended to be lethal, but it killed the shaikh. Immediately, a great cyclone hit Salim Shah's camp; afterwards, Shaikh Ala'i's body was found buried in flowers. Such a clear sign of divine blessing did little, presumably, to discourage the Mahdawis; and little to bolster the court clergy's popularity. As Blochmann writes, 'Makhdum-ul-Mulk was never popular after that'.

. Blochmann's introduction to Abu'l Fazl, *The Ain-i-Akbari*, vol. 1.

. Ibid.

. H.M. Elliot's translation in *The History of India, As Told by Its Own Historians*, vol. 5. W.H. Lowe's translation (which is what I quote unless otherwise indicated) is more sympathetic; in it, Badauni seems to be saying that the cleric's books were precious to him like 'ingots' – not bricks – of gold. There is nothing ambiguous, however, about Badauni's disgruntlement with the court clergy.

. Blochmann's introduction to Abu'l Fazl, *The Ain-i-Akbari*, vol. 1. A 'number of Turks came and surrounded our abode', Abul Fazl would write, years later, in the *Akbarnama*, remembering the moment with vestigial anxiety, perhaps.

. And defence, then as now, had one of the biggest claims on government resources. Gunpowder was expensive. So were horses, which had to be imported and were 'constantly needing replacement due to uncongenial equine conditions' in South Asia. See Michael H. Fisher, *A Short History of the Mughal Empire* (I.B. Tauris, 2016).

.Jouher, *The Tezkereh al Vakiat, or Private Memoirs of Moghul Emperor Humayun by Jouher*, trans. Major Charles Stewart (Oriental Translation Fund, 1832). The annals suggest that one of the essential features of armies at this time, big or small, was a body of accountants. Thus, the handful of men who accompanied Humayun on his Persian exile included no less than three accountants (plus an assorted muster of men including a librarian, bartender, keepers of bedding and the strongbox, and Jouher the ewer-bearer, of course).

. As Michael H. Fisher explains it, when Babur arrived in Hindustan, only about four decades earlier, 'the land itself had limited economic value' because there was so much of it that was 'potentially arable' but uncultivated. 'Control over people', therefore, 'was more valuable than control over land' – exploitative governments or zamindars would only force farmers to leave and settle elsewhere. See Fisher, *A Short History of the Mughal Empire*.

. Ibid.

. Ali Anooshahr, 'Mughals, Mongols, and Mongrels: The Challenge of Aristocracy and the Rise of the Mughal State in the *Tarikh-i Rashidi*', *Journal of Early Modern History*, vol. 18, 2014.

. *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl*, vol. 3.

. Ibid.

. Nizamuddin Ahmad, *Tabakat-i Akbari*.

. Or listening to a 'beautiful voice' read out tales of 'spiritual love' that often made Akbar cry, writes Abul Fazl, as the stars rose above and water lapped against the boat's sides.

. Nizamuddin Ahmad, *Tabakat-i Akbari*.

. 'On that dreadful night,' writes Nizamuddin, 'a foretaste of the day of judgment, the inhabitants [of Patna] were in a state of bewilderment and despair. Some endeavoured to escape by the river, but through the crowding and struggling many of them were drowned. Others endeavoured to fly by land, but were crushed under the feet of elephants and horses in the narrow lanes and streets.'

. Munim Khan was 'already about eighty' at this time. See Iqtidar Alam Khan, *The Political*